

BACKGROUND INTERPOL

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Introduction

"Enforced Disappearances as a Method of Repression"

On behalf of the International Criminal Police Organization, welcome delegates to the Model of the United Nations Instituto Oriente MUNIO 16th edition 2026. We, as a Chair, express our gratitude that you have chosen this committee to debate problems that are affecting global security, thus creating a governmental crisis.

The Chair is proud and optimistic to announce that participants will play a fundamental role in resolving this important issue. It is an honor for the Chair to guide delegates and help them develop skills such as debating, critical thinking, teamwork, and defending an ideological position.

The practice of enforced disappearance represents one of the most severe violations of fundamental rights in the international system. It involves the arrest, detention, abduction or any form of deprivation of liberty carried out by agents of the State or individuals acting with its authorization, followed by the refusal to acknowledge the act or the concealment of the fate or whereabouts of the person concerned. Historically, this mechanism has been used not only as a tool of control, but also as a method of political repression and intimidation against specific populations or opposition movements.

In recent decades, enforced disappearances have been documented in diverse contexts: from periods of internal conflict and authoritarian governance to situations of alleged national security threats. In many cases, this practice is accompanied by other violations such as inhuman treatment, arbitrary detention, and denial of legal representation. Victims are often taken without due process, held in unknown locations, and silenced outside the reach of the legal system. The psychological and social impact of this tactic extends beyond the individuals directly affected, creating widespread fear and eroding the trust between civil society and institutions.

This topic remains critically relevant for the international community, as new technologies and modern conflicts have transformed both the scope and complexity of disappearance cases. The discussion surrounding enforced disappearances as a method of repression challenges States to reaffirm their commitment to transparency, accountability and the prevention of impunity. Delegates are encouraged to address the issue from a multidimensional perspective,

considering legal frameworks, investigative cooperation, and the urgent need for victim-centered solutions rooted in justice and truth.

We, as a Chair, have decided to address the issue of enforced disappearances as a method of repression, as the committee considers it a problem that, despite frequently remaining out of debate, continues to occur in various countries globally. We, as a committee, were concerned by the impact of these acts, which not only directly affects the missing persons, but also their families and communities, who often do not obtain answers or justice.

There are still governments that use disappearance as a control tool, to punish those who have a different opinion or simply to instill fear.

The Chair considers it extremely important to present this topic in MUNIO, since it can promote a valuable conversation about how international organizations act, the mechanisms that can be strengthened and the ways to prevent the abuse of power. We, as a committee, believe that discussing this issue is a way to better understand what is happening in the world and to propose solutions from a responsible and committed perspective.

In this background, delegates will find a comprehensive overview of the causes, consequences, legal frameworks, and relevant case studies related to enforced disappearances, in order to provide a solid foundation for meaningful debate.

History of the Committee

The International Criminal Police Organization was established on September 7, 1923, in Vienna, Austria. Originally known as the International Criminal Police Commission, this initiative arose from growing concerns about cross-border crime and the urgent need for cooperation among national police forces. Decades later, in 1956, the institution adopted its current official name and expanded its mission to serve as a neutral, apolitical body facilitating international policing collaboration. The organization currently comprises 195 member states and is headquartered in Lyon, France.

The foundation of this institution marked a significant turning point in global security cooperation. After "World War I", criminal networks began to exploit the weakening of national borders, leading to the expansion of illicit activities throughout Europe and beyond. The original purpose of its founders was to create an independent mechanism for the exchange of police information, enabling law enforcement authorities from different legal systems to coordinate efforts despite political and linguistic differences. Although its functions were interrupted during "World War II", the organization was reactivated in 1946 and gradually transformed into the central hub of international policing it is today.

Throughout its history, the International Criminal Police Organization has evolved in response to the changing nature of crime. What began as a modest initiative among European countries has become a global network operating twenty-four hours a day to support national police forces. The organization has embraced innovations in law enforcement, including the development of sophisticated databases, biometric tools, and secure communication systems that allow member states to collaborate efficiently across continents.

This organization operates as a coordination platform that enables law enforcement authorities worldwide to exchange intelligence, issue alerts for individuals sought by justice, and strengthen institutional capacity to confront complex and transnational criminal activity. Among its central functions are the maintenance of shared databases, the use of international notices, and the support of joint investigations. Its areas of work include, but are not limited to, organized criminal groups, trafficking in persons, cyber-related crimes, drug routes, and violations of international humanitarian law. For instance,a Red Notice, the organization assists member countries in locating and apprehending individuals sought internationally for serious offenses. Through these

efforts, the organization remains committed to reinforcing global peace and justice.

In the current context, the organization plays a fundamental role in building law enforcement capacities through training, coordination, and technical assistance. It supports states facing limitations in infrastructure, resources, or expertise, and contributes to ensuring that all member nations can participate meaningfully in the fight against transnational crime. The organization also promotes the establishment of common standards for investigations and data management while encouraging the integration of human rights principles into policing practices.

One of the most urgent issues the organization is currently addressing is the phenomenon of enforced disappearances as a method of repression. This involves the arrest, detention, or abduction of individuals by state agents, or persons acting with their authorization or consent, followed by a refusal to acknowledge the deprivation of liberty or disclose the fate and whereabouts of the victims. Recognized as a serious violation of human rights, this practice undermines the rule of law and causes prolonged trauma for victims, their families, and entire communities. In this context, the organization's role in facilitating cooperation, locating missing persons, and ensuring accountability is even more crucial.

With more than a century of experience, the International Criminal Police Organization continues to be a pillar of international cooperation in law enforcement. Its mission remains firmly anchored in the principles of neutrality, effectiveness, and solidarity, serving as a vital link between countries in their pursuit of justice and public security. In a globalized world where crime knows no borders, the work of this organization is essential to protect human rights, uphold the rule of law, and promote lasting international security.

Long term

The issue of enforced disappearances remains as one of the most atrocious and continuing violations of human rights in the current international context. Despite several steps taken by the international community in terms of legislative harmonization, for instance, the International Convention for the Protection of All Persons from Enforced Disappearance in 2006, this crime continues to be commonly used by some States as a mechanism for repression and remotely silencing political dissent, struggle, dissent, and often indigenous peoples and other vulnerable groups. In the last 10 to 20 years, several reports by the United Nations, regional agencies and non-governmental organizations have systematically highlighted this practice, which, in addition to the depredation of human dignity involved in it, exerts serious and lasting consequences at the levels of society, politics and the economy.

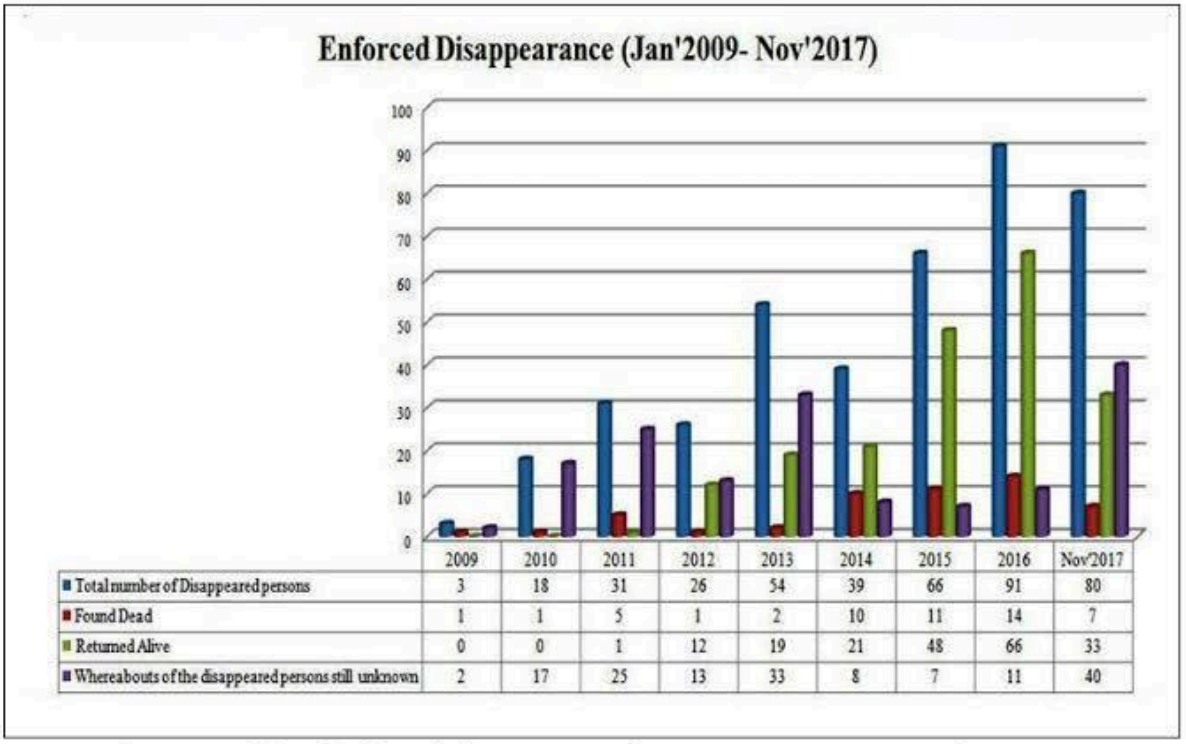
The social consequences of forced disappearance extend far beyond the person directly affected. For their families, a prolonged and overwhelming form of mourning originates known as ambiguous mourning, and this is due to the fact that they cannot be comfortable with uncertainty about the person. As a result, these people cannot experience an emotional closure and live alone with constant pain, which can be sent to their descendants.

Likewise, in all environments in which persistently unpunished forced disappearance is carried out, a culture of terror develops, the victim is discredited and the relationship with state institutions is polarized. From the point of view of the rule of law and politics, forced disappearance as punishment is an instrument of organization that dissolves the foundations of the rule of law and considers the power of the rulers illegal because it destabilizes it.

The practice detects a variant of extremely radical censorship aimed at critical voices of the regime, journalists, human rights defenders, political opponents and social leaders. This translates into a drastic reduction of civic space, the impoverishment of public debate and the consolidation of authoritarian structures.

Besides, the lack of accountability and total impunity with respect to these crimes takes root a profound dislegitimacy around citizens with their social organizations. The lack of effective mechanisms for investigation, sanction and redress not only affects the right to justice, but also weakens social cohesion and drives political disaffection. In situations such as those in Egypt or Syria, forced disappearances have occurred as a systematic policy to make the elimination of power a reality through an accumulation of terror.

Although generally approached from a legal and humanitarian perspective, the problem of forced disappearances has formidable economic consequences. On the one hand, on a microeconomic scale, the families of the missing experience a dramatic decrease in income, particularly if the victim was the primary winner. On the other hand, the costs of mobilization, legal advice and search increase the risk of poverty and economic exclusion in general.



	2009	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	Nov'2017
Total number of Disappeared persons	3	18	31	26	54	39	66	91	80
Found Dead	1	1	5	1	2	10	11	14	7
Returned Alive	0	0	1	12	19	21	48	66	33
Whereabouts of the disappeared persons still unknown	2	17	25	13	33	8	7	11	40

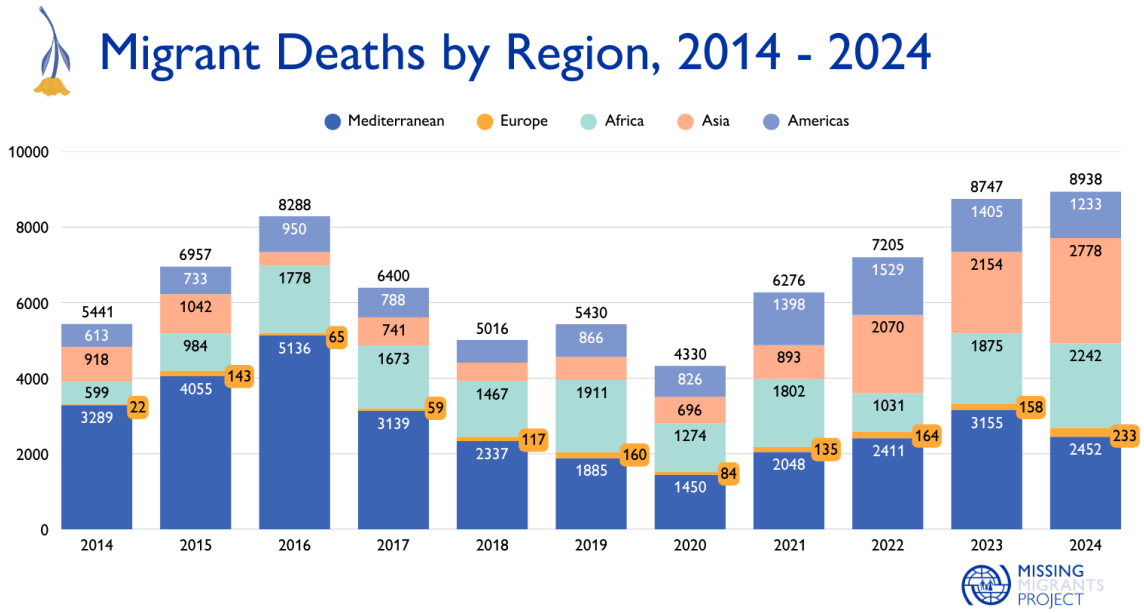
Figure: Statistics of enforced disappearance from January 2009 to November 2017

Short term

Forced disappearances have become a global problem and they are not limited to a certain region or context, they occur in almost all conflicts, even internal ones, and they are used as a method of repression against political opponents. Hundreds of thousands of people have disappeared during conflicts or periods of repression in dozens of countries around the world in recent years.

In Article 2 of the previously mentioned Convention, Enforced Disappearance is defined as arrests, detainment, abduction or any other kind of deprivation of liberty by government agents or persons or groups acting with authority, support or consent of the government, followed by a denial of said deprivation of liberty or concealing the fate or whereabouts of a missing person, which puts such a person outside the protection of the law.

In the wake of COVID-19, armed conflicts and the deportation of migrants around the world have increased and worsened the cases.



A similar situation recently occurred in Mexico, which is experiencing a catastrophic human rights crisis involving enforced disappearances. This crisis was highlighted by the discovery of an industrial-scale extermination camp in the state of Jalisco. With more than 121,000 documented disappearances, the crisis implicates collusion between state agencies and organized crime. In Teuchitlán, volunteer search groups discovered an industrial-scale "killing" field operated by the

Jalisco Cartel-New Generation. The site contained charred human remains and belongings and was equipped with crematoriums. In other states, criminal organizations often collude with local authorities to impose territorial control through disappearances while also recruiting forced labor, eliminating opposition, and instilling terror in communities. The López Obrador administration, in office from 2018 to 2024, initially prioritized high-profile cases. Some institutional progress was made, such as the creation of an Extraordinary Forensic Identification Mechanism in 2019 to address the backlog of unidentified remains. However, systemic challenges persist.

The Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) expressed concern about the arbitrary detention and enforced disappearance of Ukrainian civilians by Russian authorities. The OHCHR reported at least 407 cases of these human rights' violation of Ukrainian civilians in territories occupied by Russian forces. Enforced disappearances during prisoner transfers are not an anomaly, they are a tool used by the Russian government to intimidate prisoners and political sympathizers. These cases are increasing at an alarming rate, in flagrant violation of both domestic and international law. Russian laws regarding prisoner transfers and prison conditions are not merely deficient or administratively negligent; they actively allow and facilitate the systematic practice of the enforced disappearance of prisoners in transit.

To conclude, the most actual consequences are people and families who live in worry and hold demonstrations to find their loved ones or solve problems. This often makes the government lose credibility from their civilians and from other countries. It was found that disappearances increase the financial vulnerability of households, particularly impacting their liquid assets, income, and living costs. However, the severity of the consequences varies by household and context. The unique characteristics of each disappearance greatly influence the type and magnitude of the impact. Additionally, searching for the missing, loss of opportunities, and the psychological impact on household members have negative financial consequences for households. In many ways, victims are forced to reprioritize their time and expenses.

Topic and the United Nations

New York, August 30, 2021 (United Nations) — Enforced disappearance, strictly prohibited by international law, continues to be used worldwide as a tool for political repression and silencing dissent. Victims include political activists, journalists, human rights defenders, lawyers, and ordinary citizens suspected of opposition. This violation deprives individuals of liberty, often placing them outside legal protection and exposing them to torture or extrajudicial killing. Families suffer prolonged uncertainty about their loved ones' fate.

Recognized as one of the most serious human rights abuses, enforced disappearance may constitute a crime against humanity under international law. Victims and families have the inalienable rights to truth, justice, and reparations. The right to know the truth about disappearances and access related information is central to international efforts to combat this crime.

The UN has taken major steps to address enforced disappearances, starting with the 1992 Declaration on the Protection of All Persons from Enforced Disappearance, which set key international standards. In 2006, the UN adopted the International Convention for the Protection of All Persons from Enforced Disappearance, the first binding treaty requiring states to criminalize disappearances, investigate perpetrators, and provide reparations.

By August 2012, 91 countries had signed the Convention and 34 had ratified it, including Argentina, Brazil, Chile, and other South American nations with histories of authoritarianism and conflict. The UN Committee on Enforced Disappearances (CED), made up of independent experts, monitors state compliance by reviewing official and civil society reports, issuing recommendations to improve enforcement.

Despite progress, enforced disappearances remain a critical issue globally. On each International Day of the Victims of Enforced Disappearances (August 30), the UN reaffirms its commitment to ending this practice and supporting the rights of victims and their families to truth, justice, and reparation.

Controversy points

Why is the topic controversial?

Enforced disappearance as a method of repression is widely recognized as a controversial matter due to its direct involvement of state actors in severe violations of international law. Instead of serving as protectors of human rights, institutions of power become active participants in their violation. This practice involves the deprivation of liberty, followed by the refusal to acknowledge the act or disclose the fate or location of the individual. It generates collective fear, breaks down communities, and obstructs social organization through silence and uncertainty.

From the perspective of the International Criminal Police Organization, this issue becomes increasingly sensitive when cooperation between states is required for investigations involving national authorities or public agents. When disappearance is carried out or tolerated by those responsible for enforcing the law, international collaboration becomes highly restricted, and investigative efforts are obstructed by state secrecy, national interest, or diplomatic immunity. Additionally, political considerations often interfere with consistent responses by the international community, contributing to the perception of selective accountability and weakening the effectiveness of legal frameworks.

Moreover, this practice is not limited to past regimes or non-democratic systems. It remains present in current societies, including those governed by democratic principles. This ongoing occurrence calls into question the capacity of institutions to uphold justice and the rule of law. The long-term impact includes psychological trauma, obstruction of mourning processes, and the weakening of public trust in both national and international mechanisms

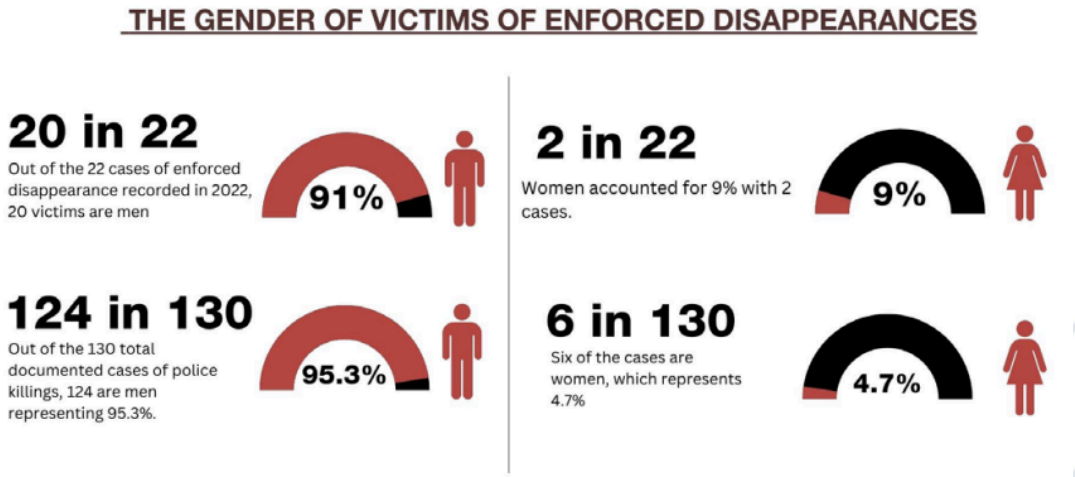
Postures on the topic:

Various positions exist regarding enforced disappearance as a means of repression, reflecting the complexity of the issue:

- Repressive or security-based stance: Some states justify the suppression of individuals under the premise of maintaining internal stability or national interest. This position allows for operations beyond legal accountability, often targeting political dissidents or human rights defenders.
- Institutional denial or omission: Many authorities avoid acknowledging such violations, often citing lack of evidence or

legal authority. This lack of recognition fosters impunity and permits the continuation of these acts.

- Human rights-based approach: International organizations, victims' families, and civil society actors assert that enforced disappearance constitutes a violation of international humanitarian and human rights standards. They advocate for truth, accountability, and legal guarantees for non-repetition.



- Legal-institutional perspective: Enforced disappearance is classified under international legal instruments as a crime against humanity. While some states have fully adopted this into national legislation, others have refused or delayed incorporation, arguing issues of sovereignty or internal governance.
- Critical and structural perspective: Academic and human rights communities often view this issue as part of a broader pattern of institutional violence, corruption, and systemic inequality. From this angle, the issue extends beyond individual cases and reflects deeper structural problems.

Why is there a debate?

The ongoing debate surrounding this issue stems from a central conflict between the need for international cooperation in criminal investigations and the political sensitivities involved when states themselves are implicated in human rights violations. While international law clearly prohibits enforced disappearance, the practical application of such norms often depends on the political will and internal dynamics of individual governments.

Within the framework of the International Criminal Police Organization, the complexity increases when cases require cooperation from entities responsible for the very crimes being investigated. Furthermore,

concerns have been raised regarding the potential misuse of international tools, such as international alerts, to pursue political objectives rather than legitimate criminal justice goals.

The absence of consistent enforcement mechanisms and the presence of selective responses by states contribute to fragmented and ineffective action. When legal processes are subordinated to political interests, the credibility of international efforts is undermined.

Therefore, the debate is not solely legal or technical but also moral and institutional. It reflects the broader struggle to balance state sovereignty with universal human rights obligations and to ensure that institutions of justice are not manipulated to protect perpetrators. Addressing enforced disappearance requires coordinated action, institutional transparency, and a firm commitment to international legal standards.

Objectives

The objectives of this committee reflect the urgent need to confront the grave and complex challenge posed by enforced disappearances, a crime that not only violates international human rights standards but also generates deep social, legal, and humanitarian consequences. In this sense, the committee seeks to establish a comprehensive framework that prioritizes prevention, accountability, and the protection of victims and their families. These objectives are designed to promote measures that strengthen the rule of law, ensure the recognition of the rights of those affected, and provide access to truth, justice, and reparation. Likewise, the committee underlines the importance of fostering cooperation among States, as enforced disappearances often transcend national borders and require coordinated international responses. Through these principles, the committee reaffirms its commitment to combat impunity, to guarantee the dignity and security of all individuals, and to work toward the eradication of this practice. The following objectives outline the specific actions that guide the committee's approach.

- Prevention: As a chair, our main objective is to prevent forced disappearances through the promotion of legislative, administrative and judicial measures that protect human rights and guarantee the rule of law. In addition, we urge delegates to thoroughly investigate all cases of enforced disappearance, using all available means to determine the truth about what happened and to find the missing persons.

- Reparation: The committee must fully recognize the right of victims and their families to comprehensive reparation, which includes restitution, compensation, rehabilitation, satisfaction and guarantees of non-repetition.

- Protection of rights: The objective is to work to ensure that the rights of people who have been victims of forced disappearance, or who have been affected by this crime are respected. This includes their right to truth, justice, reparation and to know the fate and whereabouts of their relatives.

- International cooperation: The chair seeks to facilitate cooperation between States for the investigation and prosecution of those responsible for enforced disappearances, as well as for the search and location of missing persons.

Conclusion

In conclusion, addressing the issue of Forced Disappearances as a Method of Repression is not only a look at the past but also an urgent need in the present. It is a practice that directly threatens freedom, dignity and the fundamental right to truth. Its systematic use to silence dissident voices reflects a power strategy that seeks to instill fear, curb social participation and eliminate any possibility of transformation.

This issue is especially relevant in the context of young people, who, due to their strength, ideals and capacity for mobilization, have historically been the target of this type of violence. To recognize this reality is also to recognize the importance of protecting the right to express oneself, to organize oneself and to build new forms of collective life without fear.

Reflecting on forced disappearances is, in itself, an act of resistance. It is a call not to forget, to demand justice and to ensure that these practices are not repeated. Only through the commitment to memory, truth and justice will it be possible to build a society in which no one disappears for thinking differently and in which fear is never again used as a control tool.

The Chair wishes to extend its sincere gratitude to all delegates for their dedication and commitment to addressing the grave issue of enforced disappearances. By engaging in this debate with seriousness, respect, and a spirit of collaboration, you not only contribute to the academic exercise of the Model United Nations but also to the broader effort of keeping alive the principles of justice, accountability, and human dignity. Your preparation and active participation reflect the determination of a generation that understands the importance of truth and memory, and that aspires to build a future in which no individual is silenced through fear or repression. It is our hope that this discussion will inspire continued reflection and strengthen the conviction that through dialogue, cooperation, and responsibility, we can advance towards a world where enforced disappearances become a crime of the past and never again a tool of control.

Countries

1. *Kingdom of Belgium*

Its capital is one of the three official European Union capitals. These geopolitical characteristics, along with a globalized and stable economy, make Belgium potentially attractive to international organized crime. The organized crime groups that operate in Belgium engage principally in drug crime, motor vehicle trafficking and fraud. Associated crimes that also affect Belgium are violence and firearms trafficking. The international characteristics of these crimes and their links with organized crime groups around the world make the role of the Belgian INTERPOL National Central Bureau (NCB) fundamental to maintaining national security.

2. *Kingdom of Morocco*

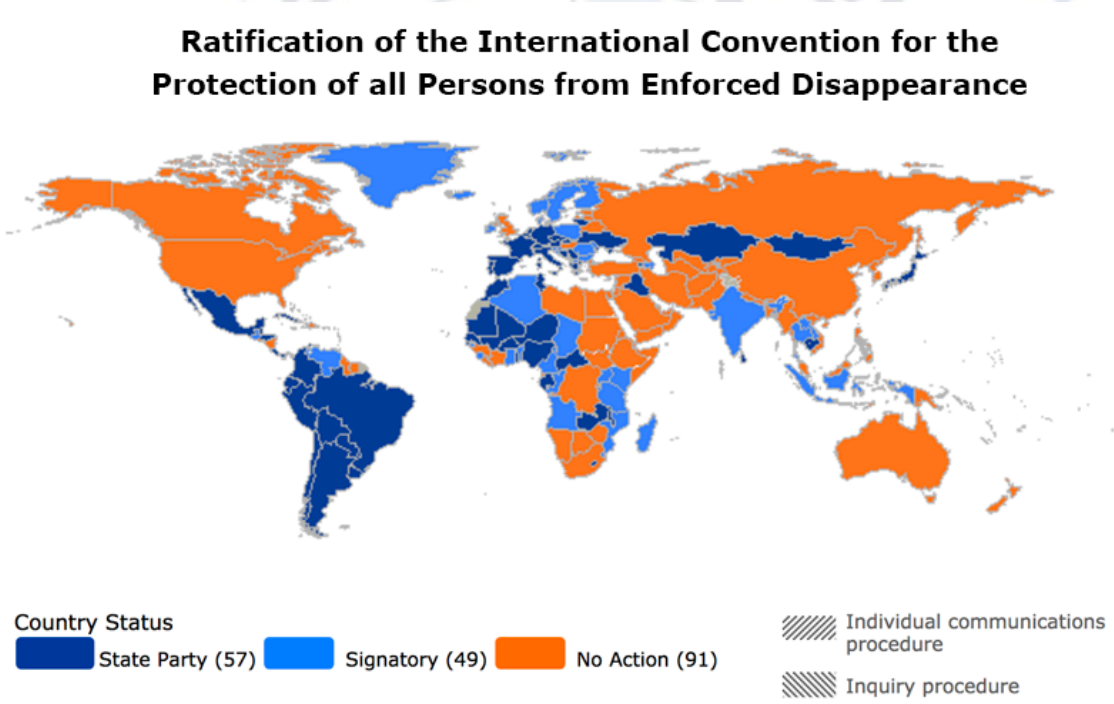
Moroccan authorities systematically detain and internally deport sub-Saharan migrants from border areas and urban centers, affecting even those with legal status or UNHCR protection, as well as minors and vulnerable people. These practices often constitute enforced disappearances, as migrants are detained without formal procedures, deprived of communication means, and transported to remote areas without notification to families or legal representatives. The study reports that Morocco's detention and deportation system creates conditions of "legal violence" that render migrants vulnerable to systematic rights violations, including enforced disappearances.

3. *United Arab Emirates*

Scores of activists in the United Arab Emirates (UAE) have been harassed, arrested and in some cases tortured in custody, according to a new report by Amnesty International that sheds light on the repressive tactics widely used by the government to silence its critics. “There is No Freedom Here:" Silencing Dissent in the UAE lifts the lid on the climate of fear that has taken hold in the country since 2011, with the authorities going to extreme lengths to stamp out any sign of dissent, criticism, or calls for reform in the wake of the mass popular uprisings in the Middle East and North Africa.

4. *United States of America*

In the United States of America, the Trump administration put in place agreements that did not comply with U.S. or international law to send people to third countries where they had no guarantees of safety. The United States of America deported nearly 1,000 Honduran and Salvadoran asylum seekers, mostly women and children, to Guatemala, where many feared they would suffer the same persecution as in their home countries. To further complicate matters, BP's detention notoriously restricts detainees' access to communication technologies, such as telephones. This prevents detainees from being able to call their families or third parties (e.g., lawyers, aid workers and advocates) to confirm their fate and location.



List of Countries:

Presidence of the Executive Committee:

1. Kingdom of Belgium
2. Kingdom of Morocco
3. United Arab Emirates:
4. United States of America:

Executive Committee:

5. Arab Republic of Egypt (African States Group)
6. Canada (American States Group)
7. Federal Republic of Germany (European States Group)
8. People's Republic of China (Asia and Pacific States Group)

Countries invited to the debate and listening countries:

9. Argentine Republic
10. French Republic
11. Japan
12. Kingdom of Saudi Arabia
13. Kingdom of Spain
14. Republic of Brazil
15. Republic of Colombia
16. Republic of India
17. Republic of Namibia
18. Republic of Turkey
19. State of Qatar
20. United Mexican States

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"Those who believe in the world are the ones meant to change it."

President: Isabella Zapata Vázquez
Moderator: Romina Hornedo Martínez
Secretary: Paloma Victoria Sandoval

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